Week 21

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 6 · LESSON 1

Text

BIG IDEA

We can't show the Bible is true just by saying the Bible says so. Thousands of ancient copies show the New Testament has been passed down accurately, so what we read is what its writers actually wrote, and that is hard to ignore.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Articles claiming an ancient document rewrites Jesus' story raise this unit's question: how do we know the Bible is true, accurate, reliable and authoritative?
2. Avoid the circular argument, "it's true because the Bible says so"; students need reasons from outside that loop.
3. No ancient text survives as an autograph (the original), only as manuscripts (copies). The question is whether there are enough accurate copies to trust what we hold.
4. The intro activity has students find a document that proves who they are, like a birth certificate or passport, to show how much weight documents can carry.
5. One Roman historian's work survives in roughly 100 copies; the New Testament in over 6,000, and over 20,000 counting more. They agree over 95%, and no difference affects theology.
6. This year's misconceptions quote real critics students may meet on TV, so teach them to check the evidence. Jonathan Morrow's Questioning the Bible helps teens with more questions.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Have I leaned on "because the Bible says so" when a student needed real reasons?
2. What surprised me about how well the New Testament has been preserved?
3. If what Paul wrote is really what Paul wrote, what in it am I still ignoring?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. Why doesn't "it's true because the Bible says so" convince someone who doesn't already believe?
2. What's the difference between an original and a copy, and why does the number of copies matter?
3. How does the evidence for the New Testament compare with what you trust in your history textbook?
4. When someone says the Bible has been changed over time, how would you respond?
5. If the New Testament says what its writers really wrote, what does that mean for how you read it?

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The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

An allegedly biblical document

0:05 Just this morning I was reading an article about a biblical document — or an allegedly biblical document — that was about 1500 to 2000 years old. This document is called the Epistle of Barnabas. The article said that this epistle claimed that Jesus never actually resurrected. In fact, it said that Jesus was simply a prophet, that Jesus ascended to heaven without dying, and that Judas Iscariot was actually crucified in Jesus's place.

0:39 Now, if you've ever read this book, then you know that none of those things are in it the way I've just described them. But here is an article that says this is true, that this is astounding new information we have about Jesus. As Christians, though, we know that this book, the Bible, is what tells us the truth of Christianity. Which raises an interesting question: how do I know this document is true? That's what this whole unit is about. All these lessons are going to walk you through it. How do we know the Bible is true? How do we know that it's accurate? How do we know that it's reliable and authoritative?

The circular argument

1:24 See, the problem is that often we get stuck in this loop where we ask the question, how do I know that the Bible is true? Well, then we say, that's because the Bible says so. Well, how do I know that the Bible says so? Well, because I know the Bible is true. And we just keep going in a circle, over and over and over again, and we never actually have anything exterior that helps us understand whether or not the Bible is actually true. We throw in there a little bit of, well, it's the inspired — I can't write — the inspired word of God. And therefore it must be true, and it must be because the Bible says so, because it's the inspired word of God, because we know it's true, and we go on and on that way.

2:24 How do I know, beyond all of those things, that this is true? How do I know that it's authoritative? How do I know that what's in these pages is actually going to teach me how to live the life that God has designed for me? That's what students need to know, and that's what we're going to explore. In this first week, we're going to talk about text — and specifically this text, the New Testament. Now, last week we ended by talking about Jesus, and all that Jesus said, and all that Jesus claimed to be, and the resurrection, all this stuff about Jesus. How do I know that what's in here about Jesus in the New Testament is accurate?

Autographs and manuscripts

3:11 Well, what's fascinating about that is that we have what's called an autograph and a manuscript. An autograph is an original copy. It's as if I actually gave my autograph, my signature. It's original to me. I wrote it, and only I can write it. That's essentially what we're talking about when we say an autograph. When we talk about texts from antiquity — the

ancient texts, those biblical times and earlier and all around that era — we have no autographs. We have nothing originally written by anybody in their physical hand. But what we do have is manuscripts, copies. Sometimes they are copies of a copy of a copy; that is entirely possible.

4:10 So the question we have to answer in this first lesson is this: do we have enough manuscripts, and do we have enough manuscripts that are accurate across all of the copies, to say that what's in here in my hand is an accurate representation of what Paul wrote, what Jesus said, what Peter wrote, and what actually happened during the days of Jesus?

Documents that prove something

4:39 So to start this process, we ask students in the introduction activity to look up a legal document that proves their existence. Think about it: you have a birth certificate, you have a driver's license, you can't get on an airplane without a driver's license or a passport. You're often asked for your Social Security card any time your identity is checked for a job or that kind of thing, right? So you have to have some kind of proof of your existence, proof that you are who you say you are. We have these legally binding documents that are proof of something. So we want students to start to see that there are documents out there even today that have this kind of power.

5:23 All right, so I want you to think about your students' textbooks in school, especially the ones that talk about ancient literature. Think of a world history textbook that's going to talk about the details of the ancient Roman Empire, Alexander the Great, some of the great armies, the movement of barbarian tribes — those kinds of things that help shape the history of the modern world, all of the things that your students learn and really consider to be actual fact. All of those things are derived from historical texts and from different things that give us clues into understanding what happened in history.

6:14 So, for instance, you have things like Natural History, by a historian named Pliny. Now, this guy was a Roman historian, and most of what he wrote about had to do with agriculture and business and economics and those kinds of things. But it gives us great insight into what Rome was like, and how to understand the Roman Empire, and some of the insights we have into their world and their technology as an ancient culture. All right. So we have not a ton of copies. It's estimated that we have roughly 100 or so — maybe less, maybe more — of something like that. And those are copies of a copy of a copy, sometimes in different languages, scattered throughout different places, those kinds of things.

7:02 Now, how much of the New Testament do we have? How much of the actual New Testament? This isn't full Bibles. I don't want you to think this is a bunch of actual full Bible copies. Sometimes they're just little pieces, little fragments, little things that we have to place together. Sometimes they're full books. Sometimes they're multiple books together. But oftentimes these are scattered all throughout the region, from the east to the west, and they're found in all kinds of different places and times. So if you put all of that together, we have roughly in excess of six thousand copies of just the New Testament. And if you put a whole

bunch of other things together, you're talking in excess of 20,000 different copies. That's a lot of copies.

7:58 Now, what happens if you say, well, how accurate are these copies? Because that's going to help us understand how accurate this is. If you put all the copies together, everything across the board is in excess of 95 percent the same. And that three to five percent is words like "the" and "a," things that may have been missing or may have been taken out — but none of it affects theology. Now, that's pretty astounding. And in your leader guide, we're giving you resources to find out some more detailed and exact numbers. I would encourage you to check those out.

8:40 Josh McDowell has actually just updated some of those numbers, and some of these have even gotten better and better over the last couple of years. So I would encourage you to check those out and share those numbers with your students, because it's almost mind-bending to think that the New Testament, as it is here, is actually more reliable and more historical than some of the stuff that's in the textbooks your students are reading and learning in school as fact. Now, I'm not saying those aren't fact. But how much more reliable is the New Testament than some of the world history books we have in schools? It's a lot more reliable. This is huge, right?

Misconception and illumination

9:21 So I do want to make one comment about the misconception and illumination, because what we've done here is slightly different from what we've done in the past. Before, the misconception was often a verse or a comment that was frequently misunderstood by students, and we wanted to point them in a direction that corrects them but also illuminates their understanding further. This year, what we did is we wanted to pull out some information from some other authors — some notable atheists and some people who don't agree with what Christianity teaches.

9:54 So you'll notice very specifically that this week we have Bart Ehrman. He is a New Testament critic and an agnostic who probably was a Christian. He understands the Bible very, very well, but he writes specifically against what the Bible teaches, and says that the Bible is not accurate. He says that we have only error-ridden copies, and that the vast majority of these are centuries removed from the originals and different from them, evidently in thousands of ways. Well, what's fascinating about that is that Bart Ehrman says that, but what we just talked about here clearly contradicts it.

10:34 So it's important — we bring this up specifically so that you can help your students navigate some of these things, because these are not obscure authors and people you never hear of. These are mainstream people in the media, sometimes on TV, often featured in National Geographic and Discovery Channel kinds of specials, where your students may come across them in the future. And we want you to be aware, so you can help make them aware, so they can say, well, you know what, let me look at these kinds of comments critically — so that they understand that just because someone like this says this, that doesn't necessarily make it true,

and so that they make sure they dive into the actual evidence. If you read on in what Bart Ehrman says — super smart guy — he doesn't really back comments like this up with a whole bunch of evidence.

11:23 One resource that I do want to point out is that Jonathan Morrow wrote an excellent book called Questioning the Bible: 11 Major Challenges to the Bible's Authority, a suggested resource inside the leader's guide. So I would suggest that you pick that up yourself, but that book is designed specifically to speak to your students. So if your students have questions about this topic specifically, if they're just stuck and you need to move on, or if they just want to know more, encourage them — or maybe you just buy it for them. Get this book and have them read through it, and then set up a different discussion on that book specifically, and it'll be a tremendous resource for them.

12:04 So if we're getting what we believe from the Bible, then we had better be sure that what the Bible says is saying it accurately. And although it may seem that we have thousands of different kinds of translations, and we have so many copies — the Bible is the best-selling book in the history of the world, and it's been copied so many times, over and over and over and over again — and although there are lots of people trying to discredit it, when you continue to look at the evidence, the Bible continues to prove itself as something that has been transmitted over the course of history accurately and reliably to what was actually recorded originally.

What that means for us

12:50 So you can be confident, and you can remind your students, as you sit in small group and encourage them and help them understand, that what Paul wrote and what Jesus said is actually what Paul wrote and what Jesus said. Now, that has incredible consequences, right? Either we listen to what Paul says and what Jesus says and what Peter says, and all that went on, and the gospel and the Old Testament and all that's going on in here — or we don't. But we can't assume that this is inaccurate.

13:25 So as you're getting into your small groups, talk with your students about this. Now that they understand that there's a reliability to this — and we're going to get even more into it in the next couple of weeks here — start to poke a little bit at them and say, well, what's this going to mean down the road? What's this going to mean today? What's this going to mean tomorrow, and next week, and in the next couple of weeks? The more you discover about the importance of this book, what is that going to mean for your life? Because the more you know about this, the less you can ignore it.